

# What are human rights?

Human rights are the basic rights and freedoms that belong to every person in the world, from birth until death.

They apply regardless of where you are from, what you believe or how you choose to live your life.

They can never be taken away, although they can sometimes be restricted – for example if a person breaks the law, or in the interests of national security.

These basic rights are based on shared values like dignity, fairness, equality, respect and independence.

These values are defined and protected by law.

In Britain our human rights are protected by the Human Rights Act 1998.

## United Nations

## Universal Declaration of Human Rights

### Marriage and Family.

Every grown-up has the right to marry and have a family if they want to. Men and women have the same rights when they are married, and when they are separated.

### The Right to Your Own Things.

Everyone has the right to own things or share them. Nobody should take our things from us without a good reason.

### Freedom of Thought.

We all have the right to believe in what we want to believe, to have a religion, or to change it if we want.

### Freedom of Expression.

We all have the right to make up our own minds, to think what we like, to say what we think, and to share our ideas with other people.

## **The Right to Public Assembly.**

We all have the right to meet our friends and to work together in peace to defend our rights. Nobody can make us join a group if we don't want to.

## **The Right to Democracy.**

We all have the right to take part in the government of our country. Every grown-up should be allowed to choose their own leaders.

## **Social Security.**

We all have the right to affordable housing, medicine, education, and childcare, enough money to live on and medical help if we are ill or old.

## **Workers' Rights.**

Every grown-up has the right to do a job, to a fair wage for their work, and to join a trade union.

## **The Right to Play.**

We all have the right to rest from work and to relax.

## **Food and Shelter for All.**

We all have the right to a good life. Mothers and children, people who are old, unemployed or disabled, and all people have the right to be cared for.

### **How do human rights help you?**

Human rights are relevant to all of us, not just those who face repression or mistreatment.

They protect you in many areas of your day-to-day life, including:

- your right to have and express your own opinions
- your right to an education

- your right to a private and family life
- your right not to be mistreated or wrongly punished by the state

### **Where do human rights come from?**

The idea that human beings should have a set of basic rights and freedoms has deep roots in Britain.

Landmark developments in Britain include:

- the Magna Carta of 1215
- the Habeas Corpus Act of 1679
- the Bill of Rights of 1689

### **The Universal Declaration of Human Rights**

The atrocities of the Second World War made the protection of human rights an international priority.

The [United Nations](#) was founded in 1945.

The United Nations allowed more than 50 Member States to contribute to the [Universal Declaration of Human Rights](#), adopted in 1948.

This was the first attempt to set out at a global level the fundamental rights and freedoms shared by all human beings.

### **The European Convention on Human Rights**

The [Universal Declaration of Human Rights](#) formed the basis for the [European Convention on Human Rights](#), adopted in 1950.

British lawyers played a key role in drafting the European Convention on Human Rights, with Winston Churchill heavily involved.

It protects the human rights of people in countries that belong to the [Council of Europe](#), including the UK.

### **The Human Rights Act 1998**

[The Human Rights Act 1998](#) made the rights set out by the European Convention on Human Rights part of our domestic law.

The Human Rights Act means that courts in the United Kingdom can hear human rights cases.

Before it was passed, people had to take their complaints to the European Court of Human Rights in Strasbourg, France.